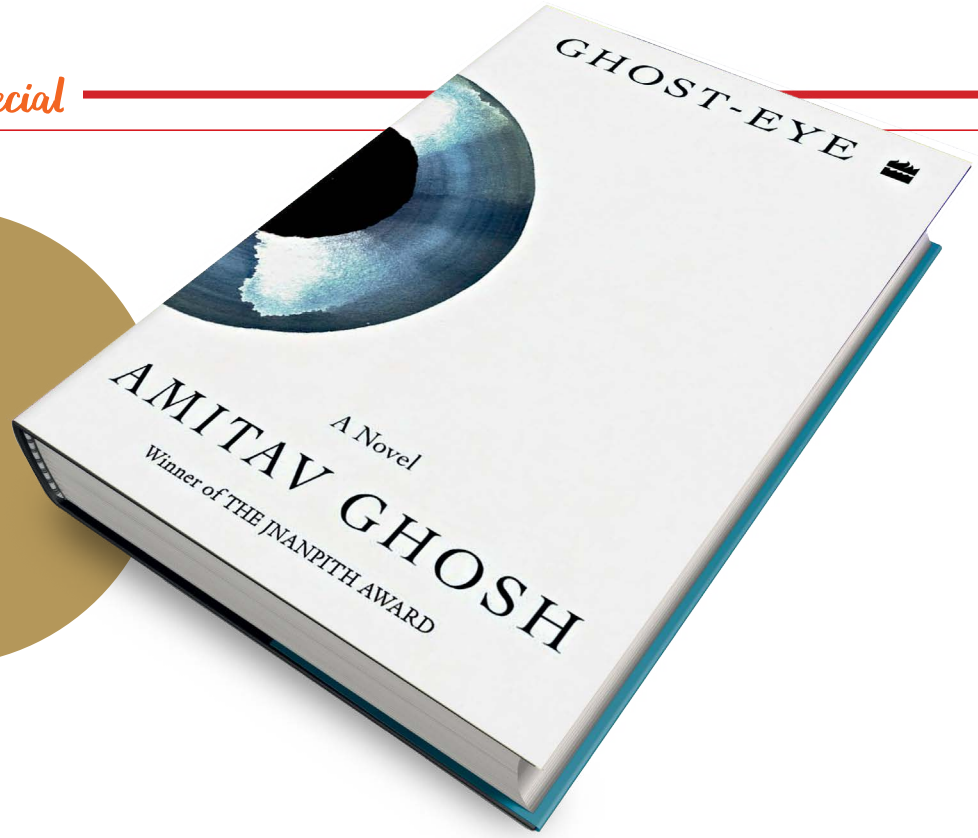
GHOST-EYE
A Novel
By Amitav Ghosh
HARPERCOLLINS/
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₹799; 336 pages



AMITAV GHOSH'S LATEST NOVEL *GHOST-EYE* BEGINS IN 1969 WITH THE GUPTAS, a vegetarian Marwari family in Calcutta, at their wits' end. Out of the blue, their three-year-old daughter Varsha demands fish and rice for lunch, claiming moreover that she has memories of a previous life, with her 'real' mother (in a little Bengali village in the Sundarbans) who taught her how to catch and cook a great many varieties of fish. Dr Shoma Bose, a psychologist and therapist specialising in children who claim to remember past lives, is intrigued by Varsha, especially after the girl clears a blind test designed to test her knowledge of fish. Half a century later, during the COVID-19 pandemic, Shoma's nephew Dinu, an antiquarian with a curious mind and a soft spot for her, decides to find out what happened when Shoma eventually took little Varsha to Lusibari, the Sundarbans village (first encountered in *The Hungry Tide*).

Talking about the novel's genesis, Ghosh says, "A friend of mine commented after reading the book that in India we grow up knowing about children with past life memories. And yet, we don't read about them in contemporary literature.... A close friend of mine grew up with vivid past life memories. He would often talk about them to his parents. One day getting off a bus in Mumbai, he actually pointed to a house and said that that was where he had lived in his last life."

Having set up this dual timeline in the late 1960s and the early 2020s, Ghosh moves back and forth between them and opens up the novel's thematic ballgame, unlocking an array of connections with his previous novels and their key motifs: climate change (*Gun Island*), ecological strife (*The Hungry Tide*), science vs the paranormal (*The Calcutta Chromosome*) and, of course, the role of the nation-state (*The Glass Palace*, *The Shadow Lines*) in all of this. Through the dynamic between Shoma and her strictly rationalist husband Monty, we get to see how a conventional, by-the-book intellect can actually be a disadvantage while processing 'cases of the reincarnation type'. A similar contrast can be seen in the two previous Ghosh characters who appear as supporting players here: marine biologist Piyali Roy (from *The Hungry Tide* and *Gun Island*) and her adoptive nephew, the globetrotting, entrepreneurial hustler Tipu whose injured eye (from a fateful encounter with a snake in *Gun Island*) is, in fact, the titular 'ghost-eye' here. Also, Tarun, Dinu's best friend growing up in Calcutta, is revealed as the great-grandson of Rajkumar Raha, the central character of *The Glass Palace*.

"One of the most difficult things for a writer is to let go of their characters at the end of a novel," says Ghosh. "In the course of writing a book these characters become so alive that they are like friends...so yes, I do often refer back to my earlier books when my characters return."

INSTEAD OF LETTING 'ACTION-HEAVY' BITS DOMINATE, GHOSH AMPS UP THE SYMBOLISM AND SUPERNATURAL IMAGERY IN THE PLOT